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A twenty-two-year journey of sustainable human resource management research: bibliometric analysis

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Abstract

Sustainability is increasingly embraced globally, and its influence extends to human resource management (HRM). Researchers worldwide are investigating sustainable human resource management (SHRM), which establishes a direct connection between HRM and the pursuit of sustainability. SHRM emphasizes incorporating sustainability practices in regular HR practices for employee benefits by offering a positive work environment, goodwill, and growth opportunities. This study aims to conduct a bibliometric analysis to look at the research trends, influential scholarly journals, prominent authors, and contributing countries within the domain of SHRM. We extensively examined a portfolio of 348 Scopus documents. To begin, bibliometric methods of Biblioshiny (RStudio) are used to trace the development of the field, assess its current state, and locate any relevant research clusters. Besides, a content analysis is performed on the research clusters to formulate a program for further study. Based on the bibliometric analysis, the study finds that SHRM aims to achieve financial, social, environmental, and HR regeneration goals. This research endeavor enhances the comprehension of sustainable practices within the realm of human resource functions, explicitly focusing on the sustainability objectives pursued by enterprises. It supports the line managers and senior management in their efforts to make SHRM a central role in the pursuit of sustainability goals. Furthermore, the researchers can utilize these findings as an outline to explore additional dimensions within the SHRM domain, employing this roadmap as a tool for guidance.

Keywords Bibliometric analysis, HRM, Research, Sustainability, SHRM

Introduction

The terms sustainability and sustainable development have gained popularity in recent times [1–6]. The concept of sustainability was once completely linked to the economy, and later it expanded to environmental [7–10], sociological, and, at last, corporate domains [11–13].

Businesses now need to create more sustainable business performance, and human resources play a significant role in this effort [14–16]. Besides, human resource management (HRM) that is sustainable is becoming more and more recognized as an important part of a successful business strategy [17, 18]. The organizations utilize various HRM functions to attain their desired goals [19]. Appropriate HRM practices in organizations play a pioneering role in an organization's long-term success by ensuring proper talent acquisition, development, and retention [20]. Sustainable development has emerged as a dominant concept in HRM [21]. Researchers have attempted to find out why the practice of sustainability is related to human resources functions, and they have

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tried to identify how the concept of sustainability is implemented in different HRM functions [22–25]. However, the concept of sustainable HRM (SHRM) is not well defined [26]. Therefore, Kramar [26] stated SHRM is used to describe both human and social consequences that enable a company to remain viable over the long period of time, or to create a sustainable organization. Ehnert [27] defined “SHRM is the sequence of planned or evolving HRM strategies and procedures designed to facilitate organizational goal accomplishment while at the same time multiplying the HRM practices over a long period of time and managing responses effects of HRM functions on the HR practices.”

Sustainable HRM focuses on the benefits of employees by ensuring a suitable work environment, providing attention to employee goodwill, and enhancing development opportunities at work [28, 29]. Lumpkin and Brigham [30] have highlighted three enduring dimensions of SHRM: futurity, continuity, and perseverance. The concept of futurity pertains to considering the future's continuity. In contrast, continuity underscores the influence of present decisions and actions on the future, and perseverance accentuates the effect of current choices and activities on the future [30]. Long-term decision making and long-term impact are central to sustainable HRM [31]. Currently, the need to employ human resources in an effective and efficient manner is balanced with the need for development in the future. Besides, SHRM puts a focus on social responsibility, while another, focus on economically rational explanation for sustainability in organizations. The objective of SHRM is to increase employees' employability growth through time, empowering employees to take ownership of their work through participatory management techniques, and maintaining a healthy work-life balance are all priorities. [32]. Sustainable Human resource policies prioritize creating appropriate, transparent processes for hiring and retaining staff, providing them with training and development opportunities, and motivating and managing performance. SHRM continuously helps to achieve the organization's strategic objective. Employees are not considered as merely tools to be utilized to achieve organization's financial goals but also considered as valuable resources so that they can contribute to their organizations, families and societies [33]. A SHRM model considers both the immediate and long-term implications of policy's implementation and analyzes organizational success in terms of environmental and social factors rather than just economic considerations [11].

Considering the brief history and advantages of SHRM, the concept is still in its development phase [18, 34]. Despite considerable contributions made to the area of sustainable HRM, the study of sustainable HRM's

features is still fragmented, diversified, and underdeveloped [35]. The meaning of SHRM is interpreted in a variety of ways by scholars, and there is debate on whether or not sustainable HRM methods are beneficial [36]. In addition, SHRM is still a relatively young field of research; there are a significant number of conceptualizations and definitions, and the number of publications in this area is rapidly increasing, all of which contribute to the difficulty of the task. To learn more about how organizations can successfully embrace sustainable HRM practises, more rigorous study on the topic is required. There was a lack of standardizing techniques and measures in research for evaluating the long-term and sustainable effectiveness of HRM practice. Sustainable HRM practice is essential to bridge the gap between academia and industrial orientation. Therefore, more studies are required to develop an effective connection between sustainability and HRM practices. This study aims to contribute robustly to the literature on sustainable HRM practices using bibliometric analysis. The contributions of this study are to provide a comprehensive archived overview of existing research and find the crucial aspects of HRM practices. More importantly, this contribution is more pertinent to developing industry, innovation, and infrastructure, aligned with the SDGs in 9. The current study investigates 22 years of SCOPUS database articles from 2000 to 2022. Primarily, we found 618 articles and ultimately selected 347 SCOPUS-indexed articles on sustainability and HRM practices. Moreover, this study provides evidence that we can collect more information from the current scientific works by conducting a comprehensive literature review using bibliometric analysis. The evidence can lead to discovering the current trends, potential future research areas, and the scope of the study on sustainability and HRM practices.

Methodology

In this methodology section, we have followed three steps. In the first step, we selected the necessary articles following the guidelines of the PRISMA framework as shown in Fig. 1 [37]. The PRISMA framework comprises a four-phase methodology (identification, screening, analysis, and reporting) [38, 39]. In the second step, we screened the selected articles. In the third step, we showed the bibliometric analysis tools and techniques to uncover evolving research trends on SHRM.

Articles selection process

Database selection

The most two common databases are SCOPUS and Web-of-Science (WoS). However, in our study, we have used only the SCOPUS database to collect the necessary documents (articles) from 2000 to 2023. There are

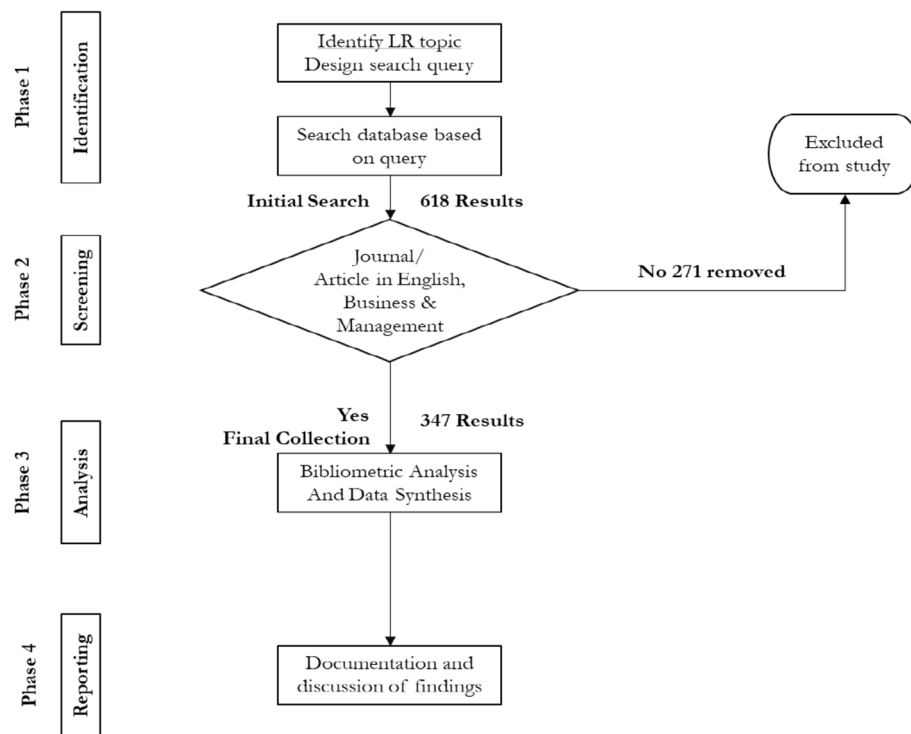


Fig. 1 PRISMA model [40]

some justifications to use SCOPUS in our study. First, the SCOPUS database tends to cover more interdisciplinary publications. [41]. Secondly, report that SCOPUS is currently in the lead, primarily due to the stringent quality assurance techniques it employs as well as the fact that it can be used as a source of bibliometric data for extensive research evaluations, research landscape studies, scientific policy evaluations, and university rankings. Finally, a substantial portion of the WoS indexes is not included in SCOPUS, although SCOPUS indexes a significant proportion of the WoS-indexed journals and many additional journals [42, 43]

Designing the search string

We looked at several previously published review articles to construct a search strategy for this bibliometric analysis [44–46]. Based on their keywords, we initially got an idea about the topic. After that, we took help from two experts in the field and reviewed the existing relevant literature to find the best search query for our study. Finally, the search query is as follows: “SHRM” OR “Sustainability in HRM” OR “Corporate Social Responsibility in HRM” OR “Strategic HRM”.

Inclusion and exclusion criteria

The included articles in this paper have been selected according to specific criteria within the field of Business

and Management. First, articles considered are exclusively from this subject area. Second, they must have been published in the English language. Third, we have excluded conference proceedings, notes, and book chapters from our selection, focusing solely on journal articles. Finally, we have limited our consideration to final published papers, omitting articles in press and unpublished materials. Following the abovementioned requirements for inclusion, applying the PRISMA principles resulted in the initial production of 618 research publications that met the prerequisites. After the exclusion criteria, we finally considered 347 research articles for conducting bibliometric analysis.

Tools and techniques for bibliometric analysis

Researchers in the field of business and management are increasingly employing the bibliometric technique to evaluate and analyze many aspects, such as authors, publications, journals, and nations [47]. *Bibliometrics* is a quantitative assessment tool that utilizes the bibliographic data of academic literature. The analysis encompasses many bibliographic elements, such as publication volume, citation count, co-authorship on social media platforms, and notable theme patterns. It is a quantitative strategy for addressing a research area’s increasing literature [48]. The bibliometrix function of R software was used to examine the bibliometrix data [49]; software such

as Gephi [50] and VOS viewer [51] were used to conduct the network analysis.

Analysis procedures

In this study, we have utilized two fundamental elements (performance evaluation and science mapping) of bibliometric analysis. Performance analysis is widely used to evaluate the efficiency of a specific domain and citation count. On the other hand, science mapping is commonly used to illustrate the organization and evolution of a particular domain graphically [52].

Analysis and findings

Summary statistics

In order to draw conclusions from the study, a comprehensive analysis of bibliometrics data was performed in the following sections. Based on the statistical overview that is shown in Table 1, 160 different sources have made contributions to the academic field of sustainable HRM. There are both local and global scientific publications included among these sources. The SCOPUS Database contains published documents such as books, research papers, articles, and conference papers from the year 2000 to 2022. The Table also recognizes and communicates the efforts of 817 researchers. These researchers published 348 documents in total (255 articles, 16 reviews, 42 chapters, 1 book, 12 conference papers, and 22 other sources). The number of published papers has increased by 21.9% per year over the period, and the average length of published research is only 4.42 years. In addition, published documents received 14.87 citations per paper. The research area appears to be growing, as demonstrated by its strong annual rate of expansion as well as its average number of citations per document. and the frequent publication of the documents. Eighty-one single-authored documents were identified. Also, the co-authorship of each individual document was recognized as 2.8. The robust global cooperation among authors from diverse nations is evident in the International Collaboration Index, which has recently reached a remarkable milestone, surging to an all-time high of 22.7%. New publications combine the ideas of environmental sustainability, CSR activities, long-term financial outcomes, and workplace flexibility into the definition and conceptualization of sustainable HRM.

Performance analysis

During the study period, the number of articles published on SHRM has been seen as a sign of academic research and interest in the subject. The total number of records in the SCOPUS database that were relevant to SHRM from the year 2000 up until the present was 348. Figure 2 provides important information concerning the SHRM

Table 1 Summary statistics

Description	Results
<i>Main information about data</i>	
Timespan	2000:2022
Sources (journals, books, etc.)	160
Documents	348
Annual growth rate %	21.9
Document average age	4.42
Average citations per doc	14.87
References	21,458
<i>Document contents</i>	
Keywords plus (ID)	627
Author's keywords (DE)	1022
<i>Authors</i>	
Authors	817
Authors of single-authored docs	60
<i>Authors collaboration</i>	
Single-authored docs	81
Co-authors per doc	2.8
International co-authorships %	22.7
<i>Document types</i>	
Article	255
Book	1
Book chapter	42
Conference paper	12
Conference review	1
Editorial	1
Erratum	1
Review	16

concept. From 2000 through 2022, the quantity of papers varies, but in 2022, 2020, and 2014, the concept achieved too much relevance from the perspective of academics. This figure shows that the field's growth rate accelerated after 2018. In 2021, the number of documents published each year went down a little, but by 2022, it went up significantly once again. In the initial stage, which encompasses the years 2000 until approximately 2008, just a few researchers have begun publishing their research. The following stage (2008–2015), as there were still many unexplored facets of the topic, saw the expansion of the discipline attract numerous scholars, and there were many fluctuations in this stage. During the last stage, which covers the years 2018–2022, the knowledge base was developed, and the growth of published documents became continuous.

Contribution by countries

The bibliometric analysis showed that the development of the academic field was influenced by many different countries as shown in Fig. 3. The diversity of countries

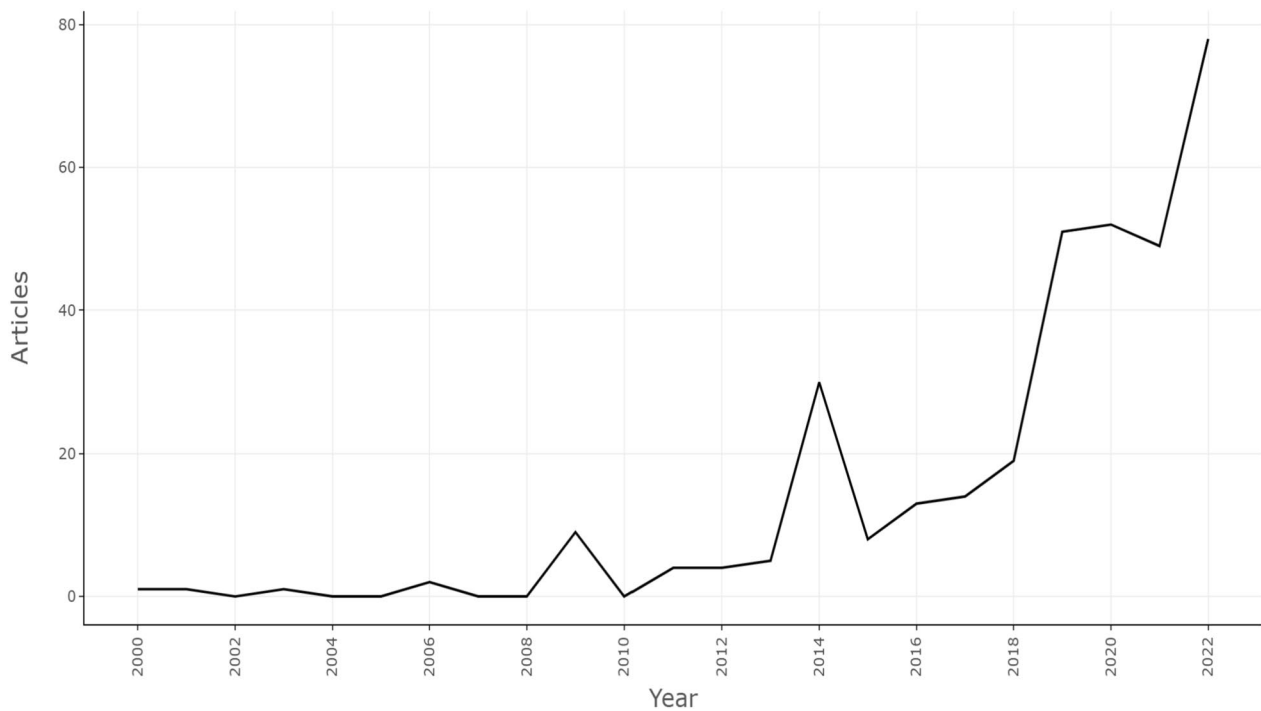


Fig. 2 Trend in annual scientific productions

among the authors demonstrates the field's pre-existing exposure to the influences of various cultures and contextual settings. Despite being a relatively new academic area, human resources management sustainability has drawn authors from several nations, indicating the information it is connected with has worldwide implications.

The first two positions are occupied by China (21) and Australia (20). Germany and Spain are tied for third place with a combined score of 17. India is the most productive among developing countries, having produced 14 documents, while the USA contributed the same as India. Aside from that, Italy and the UK have produced the

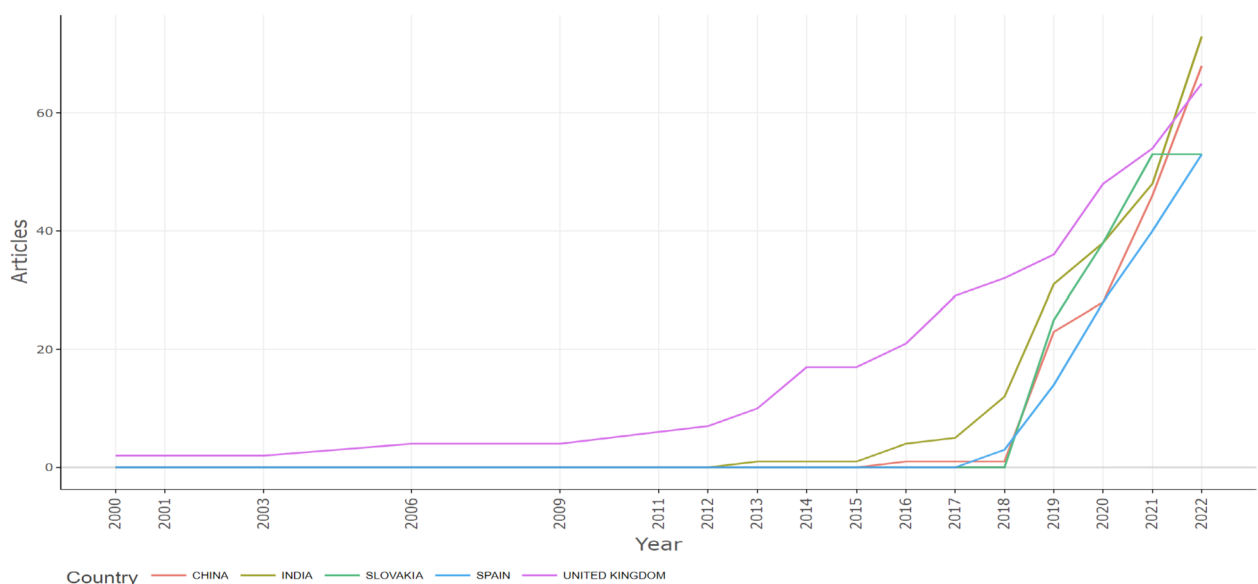


Fig. 3 Trend in the publication numbers of the countries

same number of documents, 13 in total. Brazil has generated a total of 12 documents, which is the fewest of any country in the world.

The top five countries in terms of their total contributions are listed in Table 2. The fact that there are different numbers of publications for each country shows how pure the academic field of sustainable HRM is. India, a developing country with a dramatic upward trend, published the most documents related to the topic, totaling 14. India published its first document during the year

2013 and published the most documents during the year 2022. The UK produced its first document in the year 2000, but after that, the rate of publication slowed, but by the end of the period, the number of publications had increased. Surprisingly, China had its first publication in 2016, and its authors had the most publications during that time period. Spain, on the other hand, published its first document in 2017, and it is still growing.

Source performance based on local citations

An article's impact within its own subject can be measured by how often it is cited by other scholars. Figure 4 shows a variety of regional citation counts. Sustainability was found to have the highest citation count among all journals covering the topic of SHRM that were included in the SCOPUS Database. Sustainability has been cited in the local literature 401 times between the years 2000 and 2022. Within the time frame, the International Journal of Human Resource Management received 455 local citations. After that, the Journal of Business Ethics received 337 citations, and the Journal of Clean Production had 250 citations. Many other journals, such as Int. j Human Resource Management, the Academy of Management Journal, the Journal of Cleaner Production, and Human Resource Management, are frequently cited by

Table 2 Total publications numbers of the countries

Country	Articles
China	21
Australia	20
Germany	17
Spain	17
India	14
Usa	14
Italy	13
United kingdom	13
Brazil	12

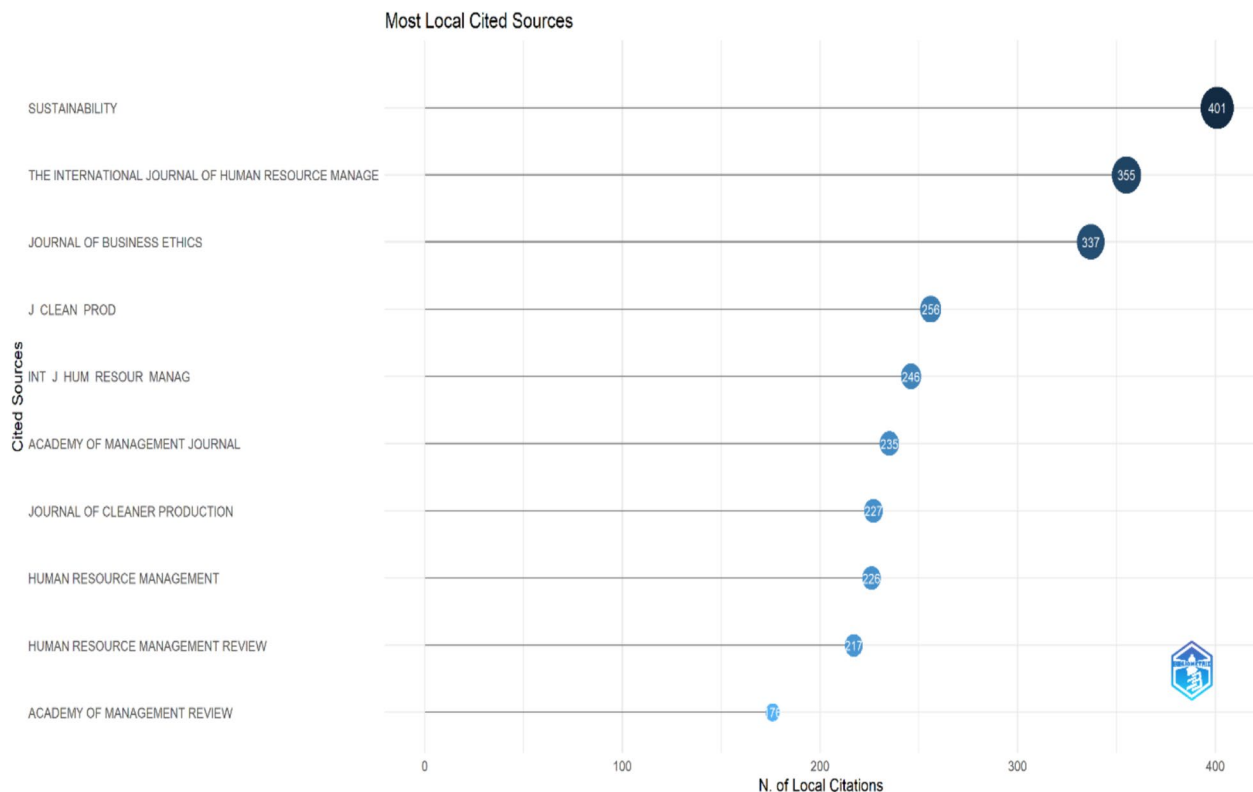


Fig. 4 Local citation of the sources

local scholars. The tremendous impact on the academic field of SHRM is indicated by the significant number of citations.

Contribution by authors

An additional advantage of bibliometric research is that it provides information on the most influential authors within a specific domain [53]. A total of 817 individuals have already been revealed as a result of the bibliometric analysis that was carried out for the purpose of this study. On the other hand, this study was able to identify the authors who were the most relevant when considering the quantity of documents released; Fig. 5 presents the top 10 of these authors. In the academic field of SHRM, Ehnert I and Mariappandar s have been ranked as the highest contributors overall. Within the allotted time frame, the authors published 11 different documents and submitted them for inclusion in the SCOPUS database. Following that, the most notable authors in the SHRM literature are Jabbour cjc, who contributed 9 documents, Kramar R and Piwower-Selej k, who each contributed 5 documents. The other five researchers have published four papers each.

Domain-specific relevance of the authors

Through the use of bibliometric data, we have also been able to determine which authors are the most frequently cited in the local region. Figure 6 provides a list of authors who have made significant contributions to the

expansion of the academic subject of sustainable HRM specifically. Ahin J-Y and Avila Ej received the most citations during the relevant time period. According to Fig. 6, the authors received a total of 116 citations. It gives the impression that the written documents by these particular individuals are the ones that contributed the most to the advancement of the field. Dos Santos LM has received 66 citations, followed by Gavronski I and Ribeiro with 41 each, Cugureo-Escofet n, Ficapal-Cusi p, and Torrent-Sellens j with 36 each, and Anilesinya A and Andrei AG with 37 and 32, respectively.

Impact of the authors

Figure 7 illustrates the findings of an evaluation that was carried out using citation analysis to assess the effects that various writers have had in the field of sustainable HRM. The h-index was used to determine the magnitude of these effects. The figure shows that Mariappanadar's ranks first on this metric. There are at least nine citations in all of Mariappanadar's published works. Jabbour Cjc had the second-highest impact. An h-index of eight citations indicates that this author is relatively well-known in their field. Ehnert I has at least six citations. The other four major authors have similar numbers of citations. The figure's low H-index scores reveal an information deficit in the study of synchronized or interconnected growth. This result also shows that the current research cannot be generalized to the point where it can be used in all future studies.

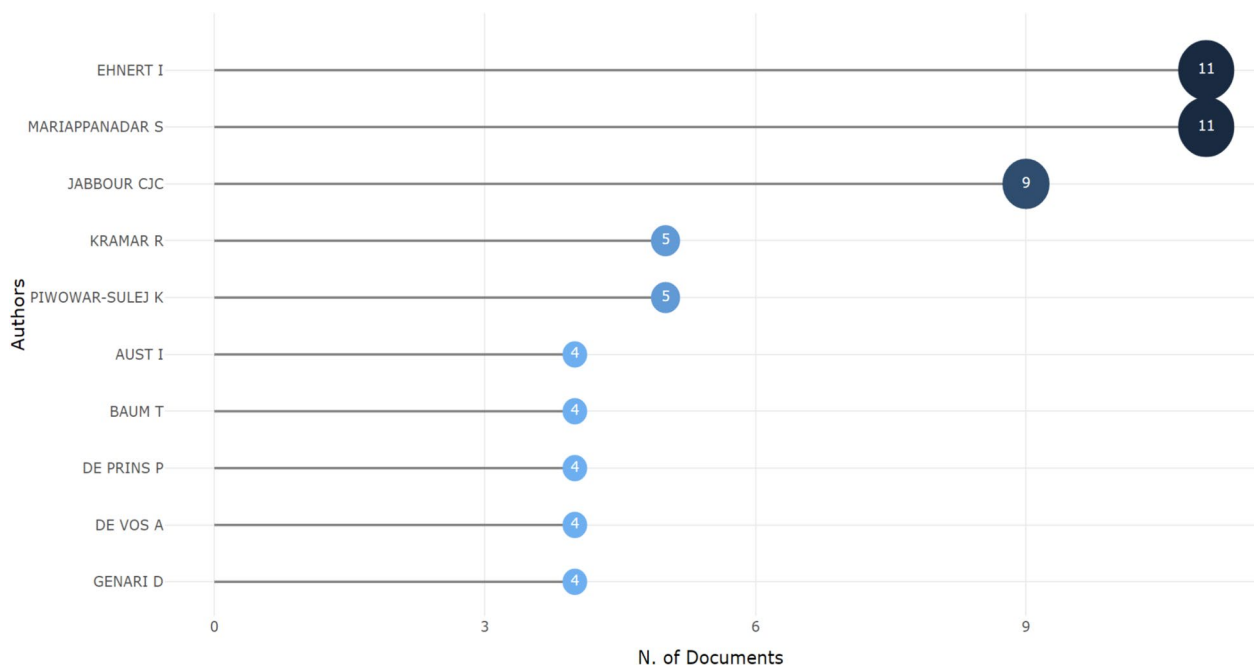


Fig. 5 Publication numbers of the authors

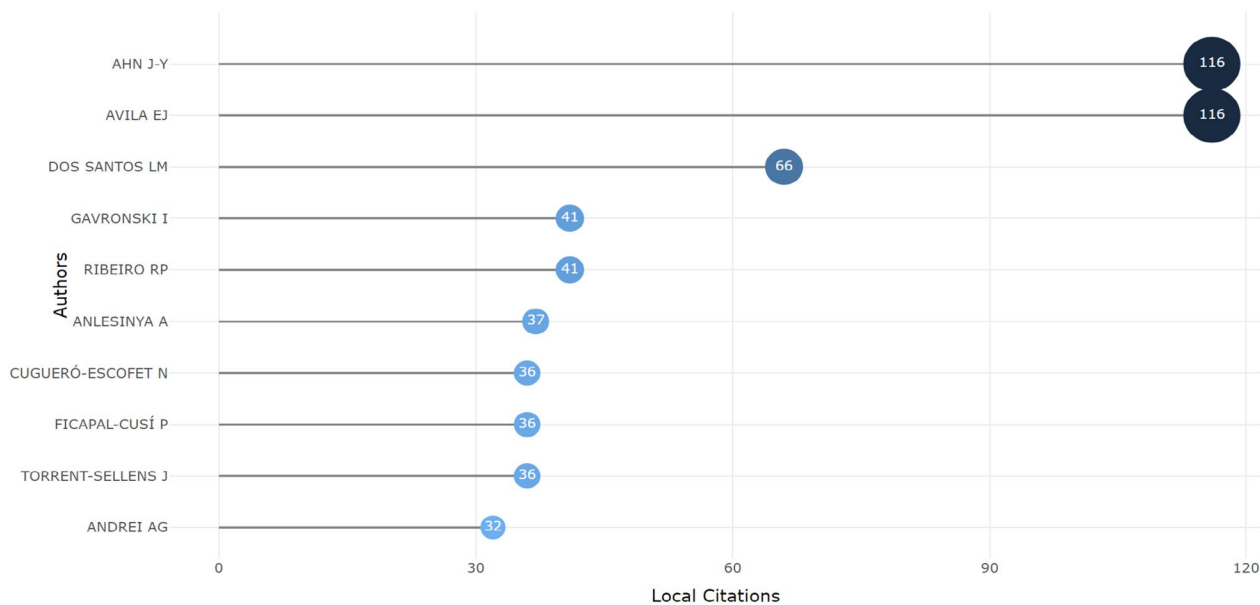


Fig. 6 Most locally cited authors

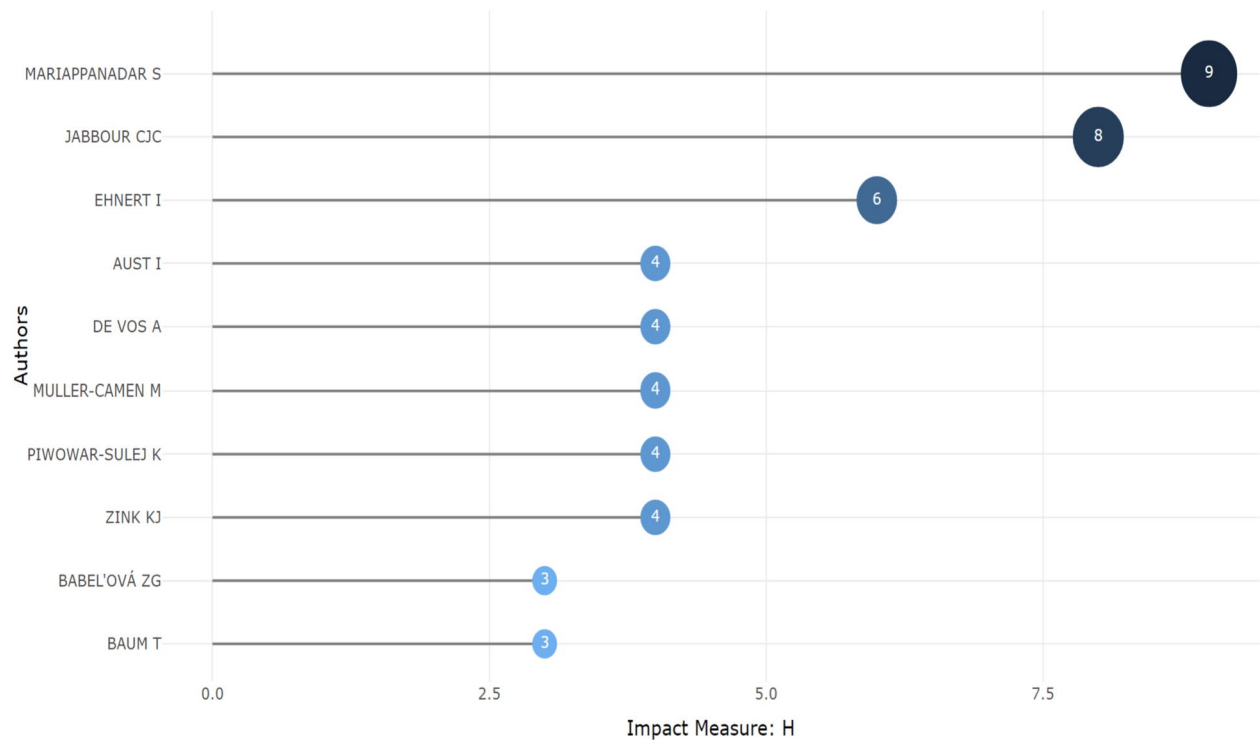


Fig. 7 Impact of the authors

Therefore, researchers have the potential to make substantial contributions by offering the essential conceptual framework of the topic, which can be utilized in a variety of research scenarios.

Contribution of institutes

The most notable affiliations in the sustainable HRM field are mapped out in Fig. 8. The Slovak University of Technology in Bratislava is connected to the most records of any other institution. Australian Catholic

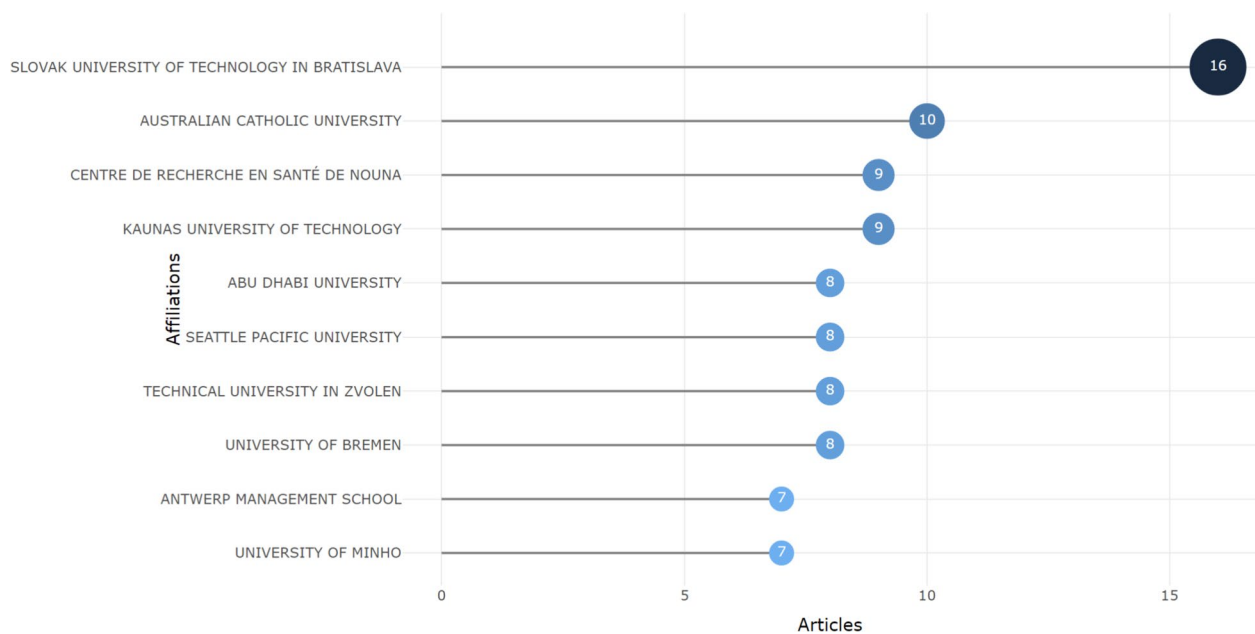


Fig. 8 Most relevant affiliations

University was the second-best contributor. The chart includes rankings for a few other universities that come from a variety of countries. It indicates that there were only a small number of institutes around the world that attempted to enhance the SHRM research field. As a result, it is clear that there is room for significant contributions from other research institutions.

The trend in annual citation

The annual publishing trend previously stated connects with the variable numbers of averaged citations per year discovered in the field of SHRM through the bibliometric study. The average number of citations per year between 2000 and 2022 is shown in Fig. 9. Citations increased from 2009 to 2011, then fell precipitously until 2012. Following that, there was a small increase in citations in 2013, and the average citation count increased slightly in

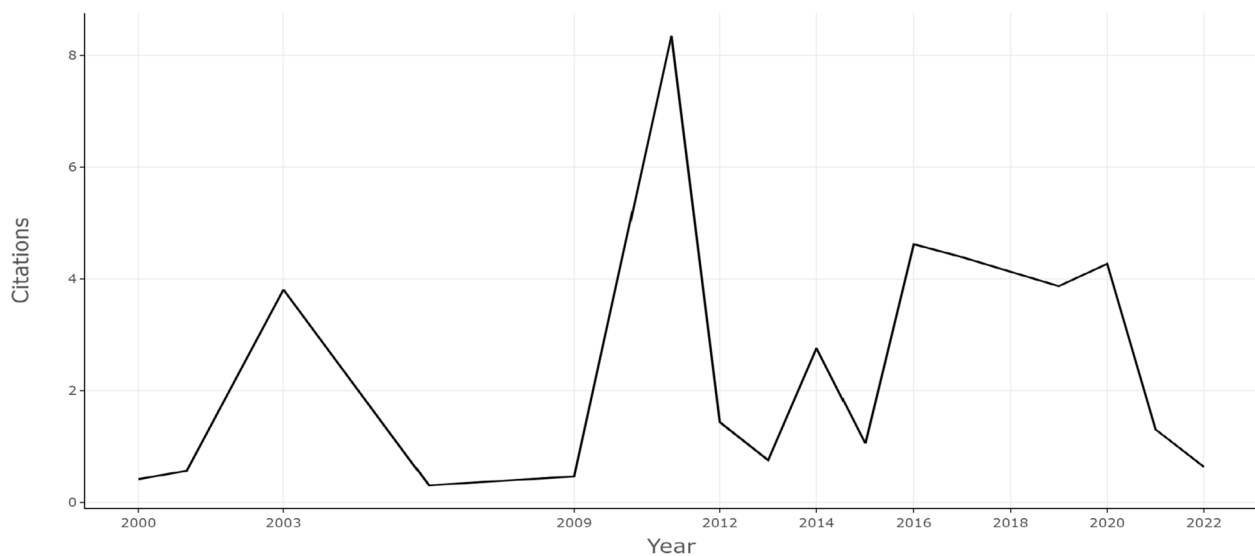


Fig. 9 Annual average citations

2014. The average number of citations received each year started to change, and then they went down by a lot after that.

Relationship between most cited research papers, authors, and Keywords

The research's three-field analysis enables the identification of sustainable HRM's most influential writers, most-cited academic publications, and most-repeated keywords. Figure 10 depicts the results of this analysis. The names of the documents are listed in the figure's left column. However, only the most-cited research papers from 2000 to 2022 are presented in this column. The names of the researchers who had the greatest impact (as determined by citation counts) on the growth of the aforementioned academic field throughout the time period may be found in the middle column. Finally, the right column shows other terms that these authors frequently use in connection with sustainable HRM. Based on the findings of the three-field analysis, it is clear that the phrase sustainable HRM has been given significant attention and has been referenced the most frequently as a keyword in the process of researching or conceiving the term and area of SHRM. Human resource management and corporate social responsibility were also popular search terms within the stated area. However, the authors' use of specialized terms such as SHRM, sustainability, green human resource management, corporate sustainability, environmental sustainability, and green HRM. In

spite of this, additional research in these subfields is required before meaningful implications can be drawn. According to the preceding statement, Ehnert I is the most influential author since his work has been cited the most frequently within the field. Other authors, in addition to Ehnert I, have had significant impacts on the SHRM research domain, including Kramar, Mariappandar s, and Pfeffer j.

Local impact of the documents

As was noted earlier, the term "local citation" refers to a document's influence on the academic field that is directly connected to the research itself. Figure 11 provides a list of the top ten papers in the given academic field that have received the most local citations until 2022. Kramar's document from 2014 came in first place, and Ehnert's document from 2016 came in second place. The document that was published by Kramar in 2014 received 116 local citations, whereas the document that was published by Ehnert in 2016 received 66 local citations, which is around half the number compared to Kramar's document (2014). These two publications shaped the academic field the most. This supports the assertion that these authors are the most influential people in sustainable HRM. The third and fourth-best contributions are the Make j 2019 and Stankeviciute z. 2018 documents, respectively. The contributions of other authors to the growth of our understanding in this field are also readily apparent in the figure.

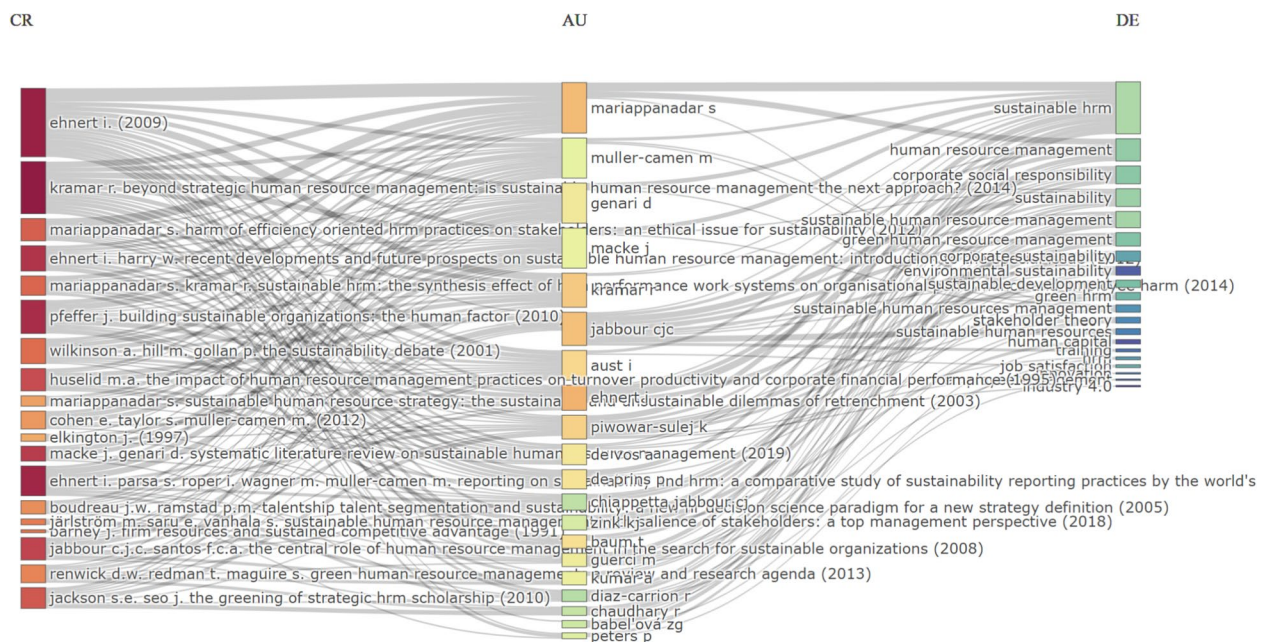


Fig. 10 Three-field analysis in sustainable HRM

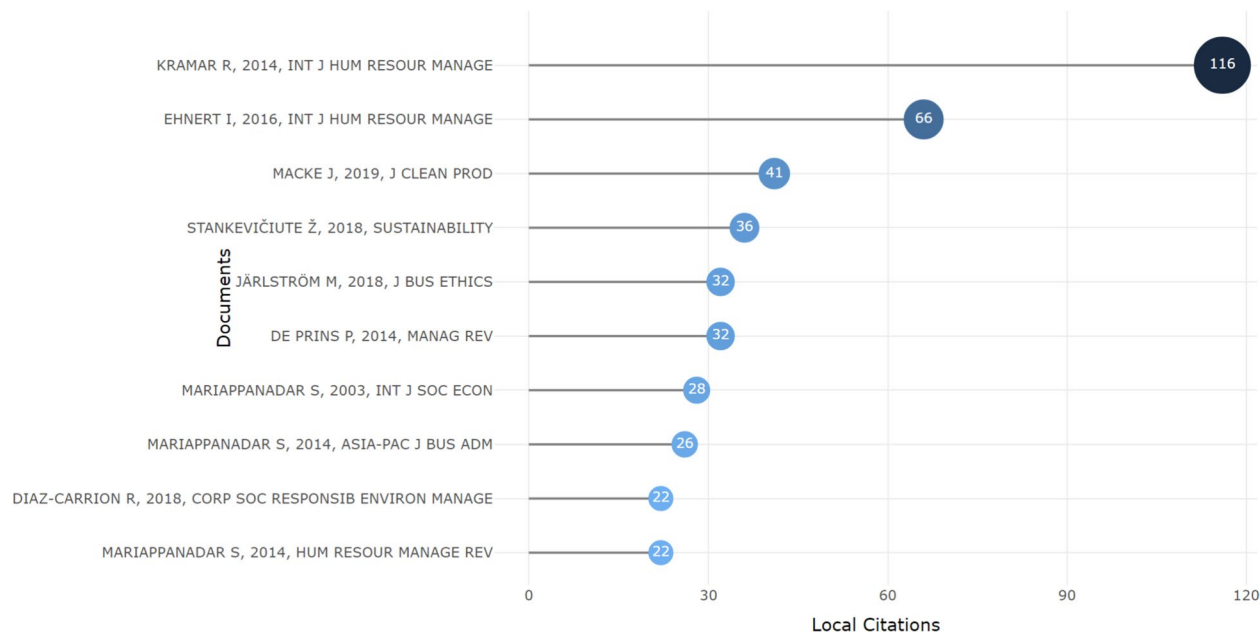


Fig. 11 Most locally cited documents

Global impact of the documents

The scope of an article’s influence in both related and unrelated fields can be measured by counting how many times it has been cited around the world. Figure 12 shows the most-cited papers on sustainable

HRM in the world during the time period being looked at. Again, Kramar R. 2014 documents received the highest number of global citations. The article Kramar R. wrote in 2014 received the most citations worldwide (334) until 2022.

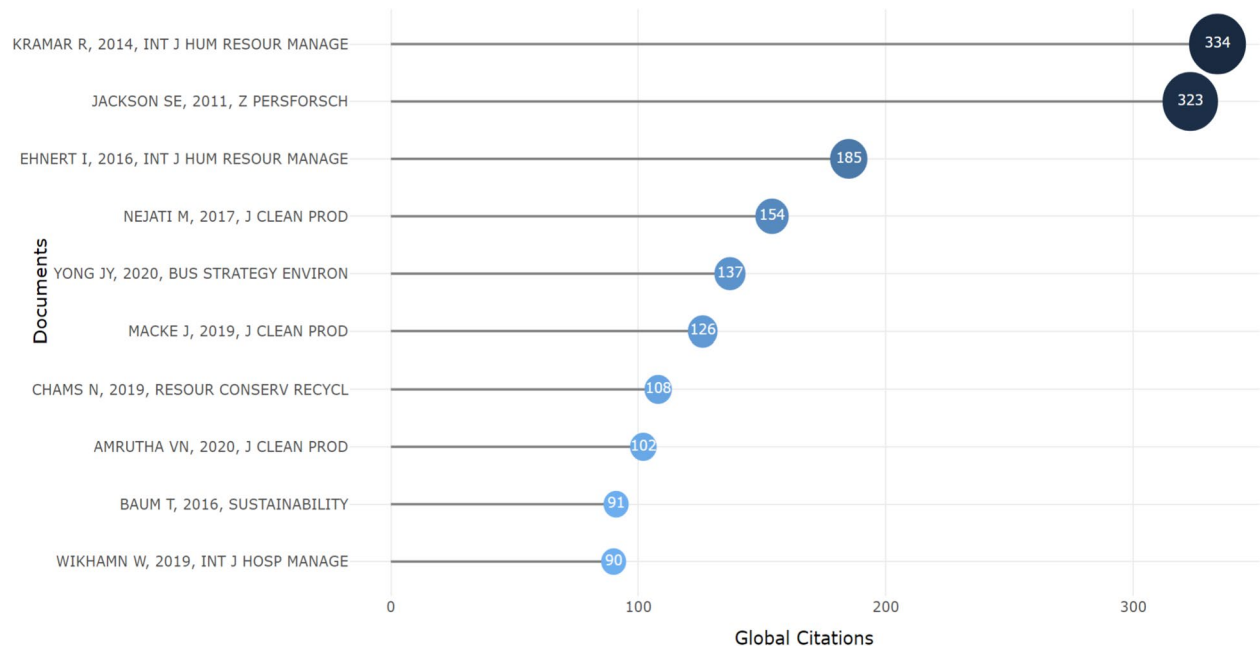


Fig. 12 Most globally cited documents

Bibliographic links of the academic journals

Conceptual subfields within the academic study of sustainable HRM were discovered by the bibliometric analysis. Figure 13 shows that there is little visual distinction between these groupings. The larger grouping (shown in red) relates mostly to sustainable development and job satisfaction. Additionally, research sub-areas are included in this cluster. Those are working conditions, decision-making, and personnel. An additional cluster, indicated by the color blue in the picture, is comprised of study subfields: workplace, employee, workforce, and human experiment in the area of sustainable HRM. Those clusters support sustainable HRM, and the field mostly supports working conditions, sustainability in the workplace, and a focus on human development.

Themes in the academic products

As previously discussed, the majority of documents in the field paid more attention to the field of HR's sustainable growth. The thematic analysis conducted for this research has also identified human resources sustainability as one of the leading factors. According to Fig. 14, human resource management sustainability is a keyword that has been utilized frequently and repeatedly by the writers. Sustainable development and sustainable allocation are the second main theme. The figure also includes themes centered around other terms that are closely

related to sustainable HRM, which are employee productivity, employee satisfaction, and decision support systems.

Discussions

To achieve a diverse array of goals, organizations have increasingly sought to integrate sustainable development principles into all levels and aspects of their operations. This shift in organizational strategy has prompted a significant discourse on the interplay between HRM and sustainable development [54]. The scholarly arena has witnessed a growing interest in SHRM, capturing the attention of academics [55]. Notably, an extensive body of literature has emerged to explore this intricate relationship. Some noteworthy contributions include HR Sustainability by [56], Sustainable Work Systems by [57], Sustainable HRM by [58] and Sustainable Leadership by [59] and Corporate social Responsibility (CSR) by [60]. SHRM endeavors to not only maintain and enhance the workforce but also acknowledges the potential adverse impacts of HRM practices on employees and the imperative to mitigate such effects [61]. SHRM practices play a crucial role in enhancing employee performance, achieving long-term goals (e.g., wealth maximization), and shedding light on an organization's sustainability. Moreover, they benefit both internal and external stakeholders. In this vein, HRM policies must align with the

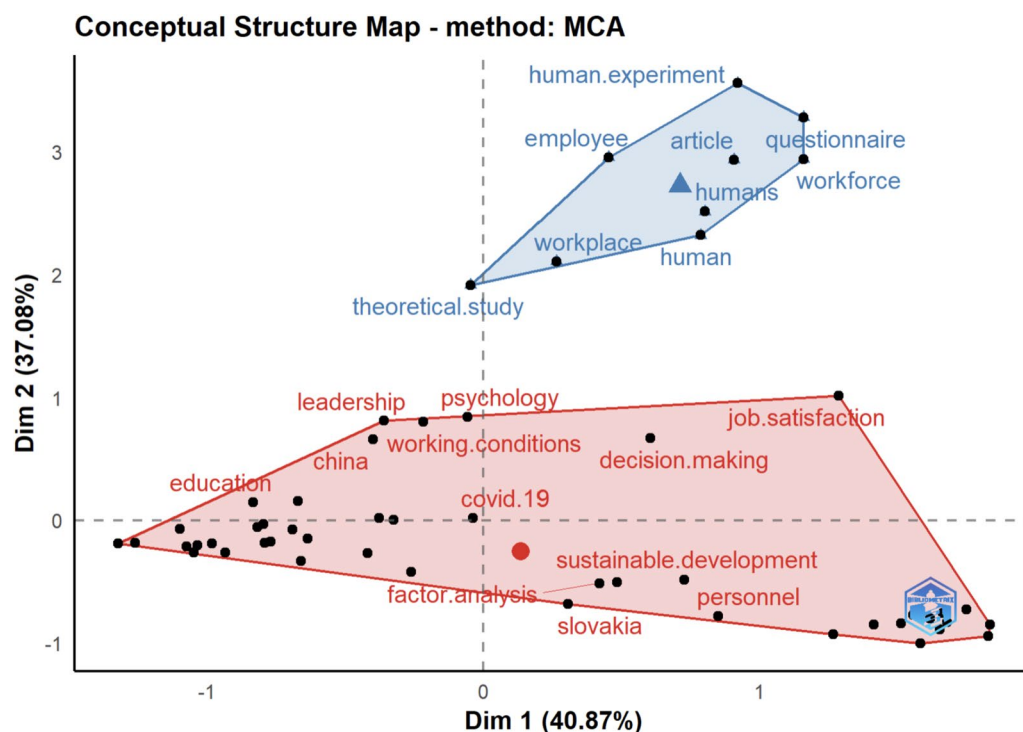


Fig. 13 Cluster analysis in sustainable HRM

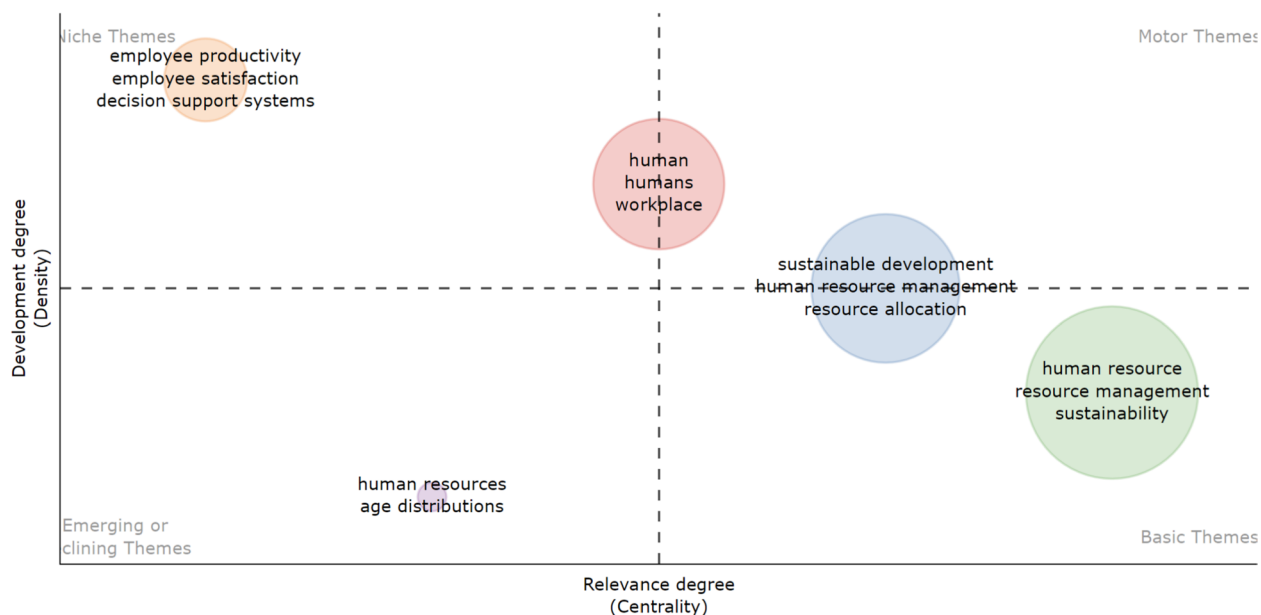


Fig. 14 Thematic map in sustainable HRM

requisites of social sustainability to fulfill the organizational objectives.

This paper elucidates the fundamental tenets of SHRM, drawing from the insights gleaned from prior research. In doing so, it contributes to the existing body of knowledge by offering a comprehensive overview of the facets that HRM must encompass to be truly sustainable. Moreover, it enriches the literature on HRM sustainability by employing a blend of bibliometric and content analyses, thus affording a more profound and holistic comprehension of this field. However, this approach highlights prominently the most discussed issues, frequently highly cited authors, focal keywords, and overarching themes that portray the research landscape. The evidence describes that a well-designed cohort of researchers has played a vital role in seminal discourse, with a number of significant, influential studies. In this field, many scholars contribute much that is invaluable for sustainable HRM practices. Notably, Kramar (2014) showed that their research secured the highest citation (334) globally by 2022. Likewise, it is noteworthy that authors from China and Australia have been at the forefront, producing a substantial volume of research documents in this domain.

Implications in theory and practices

Theoretical implications

The theoretical implications of the study reflect our understanding of the evolving relationships between HRM and sustainability. First, the paper focuses on the

paradigm shift in the theory of HRM. Traditionally, HRM was viewed as a support function that emphasized personnel management and administrative responsibilities, while this paper suggests a theoretical transformation that HRM should be viewed strategically to align its focus with achieving sustainable development goals. This theoretical transformation challenges the traditional practice of HRM and calls for the development of new theories and frameworks linked to sustainability that should be a more dynamic and strategic approach to traditional HRM theory. Second, the sustainability objectives exploration in this paper incorporates HRM regeneration dimensions along with environmental, social, and economic aspects that deepen our theoretical understanding of the sustainability phenomenon within an organization. It means sustainability is not a one-shot phenomenon rather it has multi-faceted dimensions that require comprehensive models for the interplay of diversified dimensions of sustainability within HRM concepts. Third, this paper emphasizes that HRM practices should be adaptive, and flexible, and integrate the sustainability focus in routine HR activities. It suggests a theoretical evolution of HRM practices into sustainable domains. Theoretical development implies that SHRM focuses on enhancing a positive work environment, motivating employees, and developing a positive image and goodwill for the organization. Finally, focusing on the global perspective of sustainability, SHRM implies that HRM practices should be culturally sensitive to consider various contexts. Therefore, the modern SHRM theories will acknowledge global cultural

nuance and provide guidelines for the organization to operate in a multicultural context.

Practical implications

The paper can provide guidelines for organizations, HR enthusiasts, professionals, and researchers in numerous ways: First, this study underscores the significance of integrating sustainability aspects into the regular HR activities of organizations. Organizations can consider the insight of this paper to design and implement sustainable HR practices. For example, organizations can design recruitment and selection strategies to prioritize the candidates who have sustainability knowledge and skills over others. Similarly, organizations can engage employees in sustainability initiatives, and design performance appraisals while incorporating sustainability metrics in performance evaluation. Second, the insights of this paper can be used to enhance overall employee well-being, positive work culture, goodwill, and growth opportunities of organizations. Such a positive work culture will promote sustainability values, motivate employees to actively engage in sustainability initiatives, and foster employee satisfaction which in turn, can increase the productivity and profitability of organizations while ensuring high employee morale and retention. Third, the essence of this paper can be practically used by top-level management to design and implement different HR policies aligning with sustainability practices such as training programs, employee well-being programs, and diversity and inclusion programs. Fourth, the findings of this paper can provide valuable insights for organizations to develop practical tools and frameworks to implement SHRM and accomplish sustainability goals. Fifth, organizations can assess their sustainability initiatives with regard to industry benchmarks by comparing the scholarly publications and renowned authors discussed in this paper. By involving these activities, organizations can adjust, update, and modify their activities with the latest research trends and outcomes concerning SHRM. Finally, considering sustainability as a global trend organizations will consider the necessity of aligning sustainability objectives in different regions. This reflects organizations will craft strategies to accommodate cultural and regulatory variations while complying with sustainability objectives.

Conclusion

The research has indicated that academic institutions and business organizations are progressively adopting SHRM approaches. Recognizing the advantages associated with using SHRM in organizations is more prevalent, particularly in response to the intensifying levels of competition. By providing a more comprehensive picture of the workforce, this tool empowers human resource

professionals to make decisions considering the long-term implications of actions rather than solely focusing on immediate financial consequences. However, there remains much room for theoretical progress in SHRM despite its growing attention. Our study contributes to the existing body of knowledge in SHRM by identifying influential journals, productive authors, and actively participating nations. We have analyzed academic papers spanning 2 decades to provide a comprehensive overview of this research subject. Moreover, our research findings indicate that SHRM is a concept deeply rooted in the principles of sustainable development. To enhance the level of development of this concept, there exists a notable potential to expand the scope to encompass all human resources practices, a more extensive array of countries, and diverse industry scenarios. The evolution of SHRM has been traced comprehensively from its inception to the present through this evaluation methodology. This approach has additionally facilitated the identification of pertinent keywords and clusters associated with research on SHRM. The Society for Human Resource Management continues to evolve; it is crucial to acknowledge that it is now in its early stages of development. Therefore, it is advisable to exercise caution when making sweeping assertions, as they should be grounded on empirical evidence that has yet to be extensively gathered. Given the circumstances above, the study has provided valuable assessments of the current state of SHRM research. It has also highlighted emerging areas of interest and proposed promising pathways for further exploration. The concept of SHRM possesses the potential to exert a substantial impact on the trajectory of HR practices in the next years and contribute to the pursuit of sustainable organizational operations.

Limitations and future research agenda

This study aims to conduct a bibliometric analysis to look at the research trends, influential scholarly journals, prominent authors, and contributing countries within the domain of SHRM. However, this study has some limitations. First, we only focus on the bibliometric analysis that provides quantitative insights into research patterns; thus, in the future, it is suggested that we conduct a bibliometric and systematic literature review together to get a clearer idea regarding SHRM. Second, we used content analysis to identify the knowledge gaps and research clusters, but the text interpretation may be subjective, resulting in conflicting outcomes. In the future, the researchers should focus more on the consistency of document classification and use multiple coders to eliminate subjectivity. Third, future researchers may focus more on identifying the impact of SHRM on institutional sustainability outcomes such as employees' well-being (job, family, and life

satisfaction), financial performance, and so on. Fourth, future researchers should focus on assessing the impact of SHRM on cultural and regulatory factors in different countries or regions to know the global acceptability of SHRM. Finally, it is strongly suggested that an interdisciplinary collaboration between HRM scholars, sustainability experts, and practitioners be made that might bridge the gap between theory and practice in SHRM.

Abbreviations

SHRM	Sustainable human resource management
HRM	Human resource management
CSR	Corporate social responsibility
PRISMA	Preferred Reporting Items for Systematic Reviews and Meta-Analyses
SDGs	Sustainable development goals
WoS	Web of Science
SCOPUS	Scopus database
H-index	Hirsch Index
R	R statistical software

Authors contribution

MNS conceptualized the study, supervised the research process, and contributed to the writing and critical revision of the manuscript. MAU contributed to data collection, bibliometric analysis, and interpretation of results. TAK participated in literature review, thematic analysis, and drafting of initial sections. KS supported data visualization, formatting, and referencing. MMR assisted with content validation, proofreading, and final editing. MS contributed to methodological design, verification of analytical outputs, and manuscript refinement. All authors reviewed and approved the final version of the manuscript.

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Declarations

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Consent for publication

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Competing interests

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